becoming interestingly complex, always living at risk of extinction from a devastating impact.

We have exploited the gravitational fields of planets for nearly every probe launched into space. The *Cassini* probe, for example, which visited Saturn, was gravitationally assisted twice by Venus, once by Earth (on a return flyby), and once by Jupiter. Like a multi-cushion billiard shot, trajectories from one planet to another are common. Our tiny probes would not otherwise have enough speed and energy from our rockets to reach their destination.

I am now accountable for some of the solar system's interplanetary debris. In November 2000, the main-belt asteroid 1994KA, discovered by David Levy and Carolyn Shoemaker, was named 13123–Tyson in my honor. While I enjoyed the distinction, there's no particular reason to get big-headed about it; plenty of asteroids have familiar names such as Jody, Harriet, and Thomas. There are even asteroids out there named Merlin, James Bond, and Santa. Now in the hundreds of thousands, the asteroid count might soon challenge our capacity to name them. Whether or not that day arrives, I take comfort knowing that my chunk of cosmic debris is not alone as it litters the space between the planets, being joined by a long list of other chunks named for real and fictional people.

I'm also glad that, at the moment, my asteroid is not headed toward Earth.

† No, it's not Pluto. Get over it.